and political issues, rather than only focusing on territorial disputes.[2] Simultaneously, the view in Pakistan was that this meant Kashmir was a legitimate topic for bilateral dialogue.[3] Thus, it is fair to say that from the outset each side was focused on different outcomes. Pakistan officials and others close to the security establishment with whom the author spoke in 2008 suggest the country had little to show in practice for its participation in the peace process. In their eyes, movement on Kashmir, as well as on other smaller territorial issues like the resolution of Sir Creek and the Siachen Glacier, was to take place along a parallel track with the rollback of Pakistani support for militancy. They assert that beginning in 2004 Musharraf pushed to contain militancy, even if he did not fully dismantle the infrastructure supporting it, and that over time increased his efforts. Yet, they argue, this brought no substantive reward from India. As the ruling power in Indian-administered Kashmir, it benefited from the status quo and there was a sense in Pakistan that 'New Delhi was going through the motions without actually going anywhere.'[4] This assessment is not without merit, even according to Indian interlocutors. As Rahul Roy-Chaudhury, the aforementioned Indian analyst, explained, India was aware that Pakistan viewed confidence-building as a path to conflict resolution, particularly with regard to Kashmir, and did not openly dispute this notion. No timeline was put in place, however, and India was happy to engage in confidence-building for its own sake.[5]

The composite dialogue was a formal process and took place in public view. In 2004 India and Pakistan also initiated back channel negotiations to address territorial disputes directly. These negotiations consisted of clandestine contacts between representatives from India and Pakistan, who held a series of secret meetings in third countries. The primary agenda item was finding a solution to the dispute over the status of Kashmir. While it was not the only stumbling block to peace between India and Pakistan, a resolution to the Kashmir dispute had the potential to enable the two countries to redefine their relationship and thus make peace easier to attain. According to a report by Steve Coll, which shed significant light on the back channel negotiations, the two main envoys were charged with developing a 'non-paper.' This was a document with no signatures on it, thus providing each side with deniability, but intended to be detailed enough to serve as the basis for a formal agreement.[6]